



TURTU
DESIGN +CHANGE BA2
2021

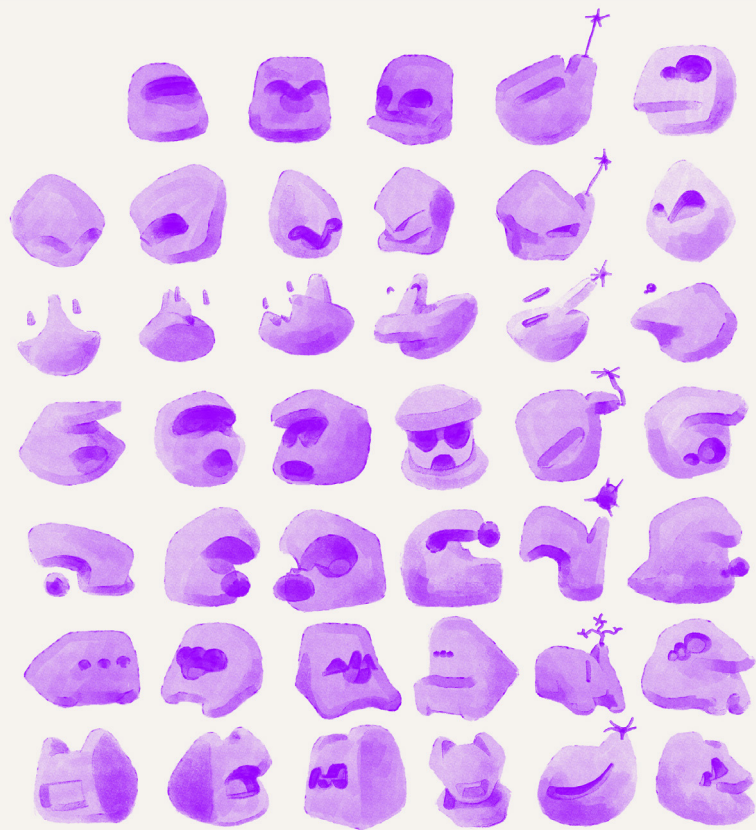


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WHAT

This report traces the design decisions made during research and ideation on refurbishing and repurposing office furniture. During the internship at Koncepteriet, one of my tasks is to find solutions for adapting old desks, storing units, and other kinds of office furniture to current standards of ergonomics and image.

WHERE

Koncepteriet presents itself as a creative company that approaches design holistically while purposefully balancing sustainability and aesthetic detail. As written in the company's description, their performance domains come from exhibitions, scenography, interior design, and furniture to public decorations and sustainable houses.

WHEN

WHY

WHO

I have applied for a one-month internship at Koncepteriet from the 4th of May to the 4th of June to learn how to better communicate with space design concepts. Stephan Hruza supervises my work at Koncepteriet while consulting me on my research and ideation.

WHO DO I DESIGN FOR/ WHO DO I DESIGN WITH



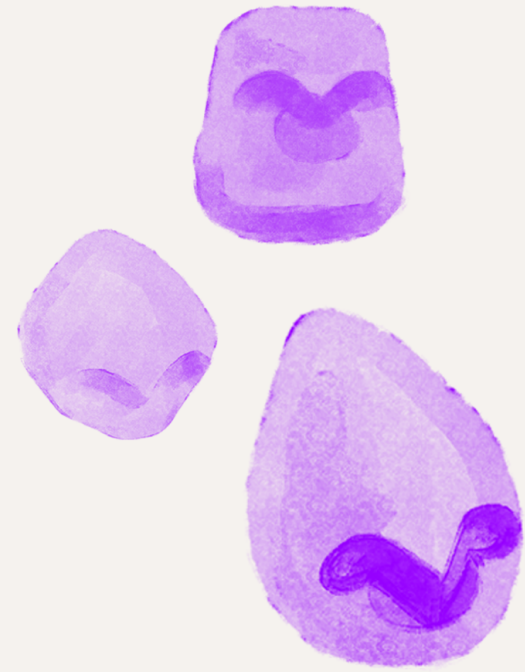
At first, Stephan advised searching for what is already there, measurement standards, commonly used materials, layouts, and office furniture design changes from when it was initially manufactured compared to today's norms. Considering that the future customer is not more specific than the usual office worker, the standard takes extra space in the design concept conversation. Therefore, the norm shows to hoard more power in the design decisions. If, as stated in the third issue of *Design Justice: Design Justice in Action*, one should design with, not for the user, there might be cases when the norm's solutions may rather be preferences, which does not decrease their relevancy in making

design decisions. Standing desks, for example, have become typical in most modern office environments, yet standing instead of sitting is not way more beneficial for one's health than a good posture and regular movement. This sort of preference may be derived from other reasons; some people say that standing desks and standing meetings increase their performance. All of this back-and-forth destabilizes the robustness of decisions. It makes me question who I should listen to and when. Should I empower the user by implementing their preferences, or should I empower the user by not supporting a faulty trend?

WHOSE IDENTITY IS IT

When it comes to style, office interior design decisions are predominantly advocating minimalism. I weighed *Brown Island's Floating in the White Sea* (2018) during the ideation process to critique the characteristics of minimalism. Yet, it is complicated to draw a firm line between cultural and working environments, as in the latter case, minimalism favors ergonomics. Decluttering is effective in shared spaces, as it supports consistency and uniformity. I deem that it is worth implementing attributes of minimalism in this project.

Digitalization benefits the decrease of paper; therefore, less furniture is needed for archiving. More room implies adverser acoustics and requirements for inventive alternatives to create division in the office. Explicit fabrics, timber, or cork are commonly utilized to produce sound-absorbing and segregating panels. I propose cork and recycled wool felt as practical, sustainable options. Both of these materials are often familiar and gratifying to the user. Inspired by the initial graphic design decisions of the magazine *Bang* (2016), I submit visual conventionality to perform as a *Trojan horse* and not distract the user by implementing several eccentric details. Previously I regarded irregular recycled velvet as a coating atop the cork panels because of its highly sound-absorbing qualities. Nevertheless, I am afraid patchy velvet would disadvantage the following detail I am yet to present.





WHO DO I TALK TO/ HOW DO I TALK

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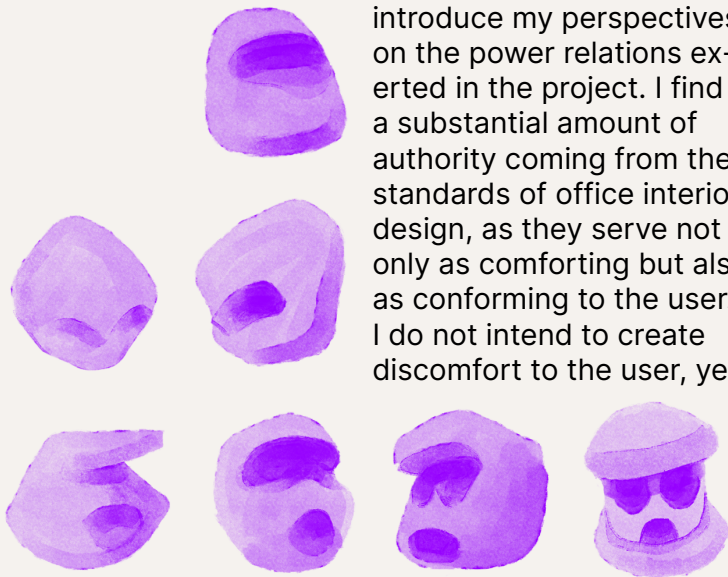
I am concerned about being dishonest to the user by concealing the design concept from plain sight. Refurbishing to mask any traces of the previous service may change the life cycle of the furniture from linear to circular. On the other hand, by clandestine infiltration into the norm, the design may not stim-

ulate the user to contemplate the consequences of wasting furniture. Hence, I am pondering a method of executing the recycling aspect as part of the user experience. I attempt to install the circular lifespan into the norm of office interior design, not only physically but also conceptually. The designer must

guide the user to see, understand, and relate to the change. I propose to coat the worn-out wood of the furniture with a dyed tint lacquer to conserve and memorialize the proof of second-hand usage. The presence of scratches and stains must not be hidden but instead displayed with pride.

WHO HAS THE POWER

Design activism empowers the designer. Based on Michael Foucault's fundamental concept of *knowledge/power* (1980), I stress the evidence that some designers are disadvantaged by their lack of design tools, practices, and experience. Here I introduce my perspectives on the power relations exerted in the project. I find a substantial amount of authority coming from the standards of office interior design, as they serve not only as comforting but also as conforming to the user. I do not intend to create discomfort to the user, yet



I plot to challenge their viewpoint on the concept of recycled furniture. I recognize one of the most reliable power resources of the designer to be research because it may counter-weight the influence of the general practices. Motivated by Steven Heller's *Citizen Designer* (2003), I aim to push the cultural envelope by generating what I understand to be good design and, hence, good citizenship. In my opinion, according to the circumstance, good citizenship determines dissecting conformity while preserving comfort.

Making the user aware of the design decisions is essential to reduce the tension between the power relations. Awareness leads to familiarity, and familiar topics are easier to debate or accept. I find design identity relevant to design evolution, as it resembles a milestone for newly implemented design decisions. Design identity can be easily referred to and makes it less probable for a design to be perceived as strange. Passive design does not stand for good citizenship as it does not build an identity but instead retains itself in

anonymity and maintains the status quo. Besides, based on what Anna Sofie Mørch Bendixen states in *On the Political Power of the Zine Aesthetic Good*, the design must be transparent because it empowers the user by depicting how it is built. Transparency keeps the user from being alienated by the design. It allows repairing and changing.

WHAT WAS IT BUILT FOR/ WHAT WAS IT BROKEN FOR

One day before the beginning of the internship, I found among my sketching tools a 0.7 mm mechanical pencil, which I used a few years ago while learning architectural drawing. This pencil was kept out of use but carried along with other functioning tools that I own. Thinking that I will try again to fix it at some point in the future, the pencil became more of an artifact, a souvenir of my learning experience. The defective part of the pencil was the lead guide (or lead sleeve), the metal tube at the tip of the pencil, which supports the carbon mine from tearing easily. The lead guide was bent, and the carbon mine could not go through it. After a few try-outs at straightening the lead guide, I have decided to detach it permanently to repurpose its absence. Now the carbon mine is more fragile, and in case it shatters, I immediately

get to know that I am pressing too hard. If I apply a constant force, the mine will not break. I use this new function to be more aware of my stress level while working. Therefore, the pencil's defect was physically identical, having the lead guide as an obstacle. Still, once the purpose of this particular piece was changed, the reparation process became significantly less demanding. The perfectionist's fixation on functionality as incipiently intended may lead to an end or pause of the design process. My suggestion is to reconsider the benefits of a design decision openly and adapt the situation to one's conditions. In other words, do not fix it to be as it was initially manufactured, but rather channel the deficit towards your necessities.



WHAT HAVE I LEARNED

In conclusion, the Koncepteriet internship allowed me to exercise my skills while benefiting of a generous amount of feedback from Stephan Hruza. I have developed a more robust awareness of design identity. The tasks have encouraged me to see *what is already there* in order to design *with*, instead of *for*.





REFERENCES

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Brown Island (2018) *Floating in the White Sea*

Alexandra Falagara, Brita Lindvall (2016) *Norm Critical design - what is it | ADA*

Michael Foucault (1980), *Knowledge/Power*

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Anna Sofie Mørch Bendixen, *On the Political Power of the Zine Aesthetic Good*